

TEST OF ENDURANCE

With crowds lining the streets and athletes pushing their limits, **Ironman 70.3** delivered moments of grit, community, and quiet triumph.

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The bike stand in front of Miramar Beach is a busy place the day before the fifth edition of Ironman 70.3 in Goa. It is filled with athletes attempting the 1.9km swim, 90km bike, and 21.1km marathon, who come a day early to drop their bikes off ahead of the race.

Those returning might greet old faces or study the ideal placement for a fast transition the next day, while first-timers may be more skittish with excitement. All are preparing for what lies ahead.

To the uninitiated, the thought of attempting the course is imposing. However, that underlines something fundamental about Ironman: every person who attempts it is fuelled by passion, determination, even a touch of craziness. There is a personal story behind every single participant who lines up for an Ironman 70.3.

A way of life

Triathlon has become a way of life for Shilpa Dugar (**facing page: extreme right, top**). An architect from Coimbatore, her childhood sports background provided an avenue into endurance sport, which soon became a passion. Shilpa performed impressively, finishing third in the 50–54 age category and qualifying for the World Championship for the second time.

She came into the race open-minded. “I just wanted to do whatever best was possible in the event. It was not a hard and fast rule that I want this or I want that. “Just keep calm and focus on whatever you have trained for, and finish the race in a good way,” she said, explaining how she dealt with tough conditions, including the heat and humidity that made the latter two legs especially difficult.

“You are only your competitor, you are not competing with someone else.” She will head to the Ironman World Championship in Nice in 2026 after accepting a roll-down qualification position (a total of 50 World Championship slots were up for grabs at Ironman 70.3 Goa, with the top qualifier in each category receiving one slot, while

the remainder were allocated based on a performance ranking adjusted for age category). “The World Championship experience is amazing, and I didn’t want to miss out if I got a slot,” she said. “You learn a lot when you see the world’s best athletes over there.”

Another person making a Goa return was Hardik Vaghela (**facing page: middle**), taking part for the second time. The head of a VFX production house in Pune, he began endurance sport as a challenge to himself. “My goal was to do a full Ironman when I was 40. So I started at 37, I’m 40 now. In August this year, 2025, I did a full Ironman (140.6 miles in total) in Copenhagen,” he said.

Goa provided more success, as Hardik got through the heat (“I was taking ice baths at the aid station”) to better his 2024 time by 10 minutes. He celebrated by breaking out into the iconic Shah Rukh Khan pose, arms aloft as he crossed the finishing line.

For Hardik, endurance sport has become a lifestyle. “This is something which I think everyone should get into after you’re 35, 40; you have to work towards becoming an athlete. It doesn’t matter which sport it is, but I think everyone should,” he elaborated.

